

LESSON 1

INTRODUCTION: DEFINITIONS AND CONCEPTS IN ACTING

1.1 Introduction

In this first lesson, we shall endeavour to understand the basics of acting by defining the concept acting and other related terms. We shall group the terms into those that relate to the actor and those that relate to acting. Ultimately, the purpose of this lesson is to enable you understand fundamental concepts and terms in acting, differentiate between terms that are problematic and to group them into their correct groupings.

1.2 Lesson Learning Outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

- 1.2.1 Define at least five key terms in acting
- 1.2.2 Differentiate between the term actor and character and their roles,
- 1.2.3 Group the acting terms in their respective and relative groups

1.2.1 Operational definitions of terms in acting

If you're just starting out in professional acting, the learning curve may be steep. The world of entertainment is broad and full of details, many of which you will have to master to perform your job effectively. Whether you are just auditioning or you've landed your first role, chances are you'll come face-to-face with some terminology you don't quite understand.

We've compiled a list of important terms for beginners to understand, so you can hit the ground running in your acting career. While this is not a comprehensive list, it should help you become acclimated to your new surroundings.

ACTING AREA: That area within the performance space within which the actor may move in full view of the audience. Also, a specific portion of such an area actually used for acting during all or part of a performance.

ACTION: 1) The physical movement of an actor on the stage. 2) The movement or development of the plot of a dramatic work, or an incident in that movement, as it is revealed or meant to be revealed by actors on the stage through dialogue, physical movement, etc. Short for "dramatic action." 3. What the director says to indicate that the camera is rolling and a scene has started

ACTOR: Originally a male performer in a play, with "actress" used for women. Today, "actor" is increasingly used for both male and female performers.

Ad-Lib: When an actor goes off-script and is expected to improvise in a scene.

Adjustment: A change in direction regarding the playing of certain material.

Advance: An amount of money paid before work has started to secure a professional's place on a production.

Aside: A bit of dialogue directed only at the audience on stage, unheard by other characters.

Audition: A try-out for a role.

Back to one: A verbal cue indicating actors should return to where they started a scene.

Background: Extras in a production. Often the verbal equivalent of 'action!' for extras in a film production.

Backstage: The area behind the stage in a production or unseen by the audience.

Beat: A deliberate pause in dialogue or action.

Black out: When all stage lights are shut down.

Blocking: The physical movements orchestrated in a scene.

Booking: Formally scheduling an actor for a role.

Breaking character: When an actor stops acting and steps out of their role.

Call back: A second audition, in which an actor is 'called back' to show their skills again.

Call sheet: The list of schedules for all cast and crew in a production.

Camera left: When performers take up the left side of the shot from the camera operator's perspective.

Camera right: When performers take up the right side of the shot from the camera operator's perspective.

Camera ready: The state of being ready for filming, with hair, makeup, and costuming done.

Casting: The process of choosing the performers for a production, done by the casting director, director, or other professionals.

Closing off: When an actor turns away from the audience.

Cold reading: In an audition, when an actor is asked to use material they haven't studied or seen previously.

Commission: A portion of an actor's earnings taken by an agent or manager.

Craft services: The on-set table containing food for cast and crew on a production.

Cue: A signal for an actor to begin or continue their performing.

Cut: The verbal cue for filming to stop.

Dailies: Raw footage shot on the same day.

Demo reel: A compilation of highlights of an actor's previous on-camera roles.

Downstage: The section of the stage that is closest to the audience.

Dress rehearsal: A rehearsal in full costume, usually right before an actual show.

Exit: A stage direction indicating an actor should leave the stage.

Eye line: The direction or point an actor should be looking at in a scene or shot.

Feature: A full-length film.

Fourth wall: The imaginary area that separates an actor from the audience. The fourth wall is broken when an actor makes an aside directly to the audience.

FX: Special effects.

Holding: The area extras wait while not on set.

Hot set: A set that is ready for filming.

Improvisation: When an actor performs spontaneously with no script.

Mark: The exact position assigned to an actor on set.

Monologue: The term for a lengthy speech given by a single actor in a scene.

Motivation: The 'why' behind a character's actions.

Off book: When an actor has their lines completely memorized and does not need to refer to a script.

On book: When an actor has not yet memorized their script.

On hold: When a casting director identifies that they want an actor for a production, but has not yet formally hired them.

Open call: A day for auditions open to anyone.

Opening up: When an actor turns toward the audience.

Out of frame: When a performer is outside of the camera's field of view.

Pace: The speed at which a scene unfolds, or the speed at which actors deliver their lines.

Pantomime: When actors in a scene pretend to speak.

Pick up: When a scene is started at a place aside from its beginning.

Places: A command to inform performers to take their assigned positions on stage.

Props: The objects used by actors in a scene.

Rush call: Last-minute booking of actors or extras.

Script: The written form of a production, containing all actors' lines and directions.

Sides: Pages or scenes from a script.

Slate: A quick statement of a performer's information before an audition begins.

Soliloquy: A long speech by an actor without anyone else on stage, sometimes directed at the audience.

Spiking the lens: When an actor looks directly into the camera during filming.

Stage left: The area to the actor's left.

Stage right: The area to the actor's right.

Standby: The verbal indication that actors should be ready and awaiting their cue.

Take: A shot in progress.

Upstage: The part of the stage farthest away from the audience.

Wrap: The end of filming for a day.

E-tivity 1.2.1 – Definitions and concepts in stage acting

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	1.2.1
Title	Definitions and concepts in Stage acting
Purpose	The purpose of this E-tivity is to enable you to define key elements in acting.
Brief summary of overall task	Watch video on this link https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hsSqf2Dxmbw by Sanskriti Read information in the link below https://pennytempletonstudio.com/acting-resources/glossary-of-acting-terms/ and https://www.stagemilk.com/actors-dictionary/
Spark	 AL PACINO ON STAGE

Individual task	Look for terms like acting, actor, stage, ad lib and pantomime and mime in the online dictionaries.
Interaction begins	a) Post your definitions to the discussion forum b) Provide positive and constructive feedback on the team learners 'views and ideas. Do this on the discussion forum 1.2.1
E-moderator interventions	1 Ensure that learners are focused on the contents and context of discussion. 2 Stimulate further learning and generation of new ideas. 3 Provide feedback on the learning progress. 4 Round-up the E-tivity
Schedule and time	This task should take two hours
Next	Definition of often confusing terms in acting

1.2.2 Confusing terms in acting

There are several terms that are confusing in acting. Such terms include mime and pantomime, actor and character, playwright and writer, script and story. It is important that these terms be defined at the onset so that when you use them, you do not confuse their usage.

Actor: As defined earlier on, this is the person who takes on role in a story. Person (male or female) whose role is to play a character other than his/her own. Although the term 'actress' is sometimes still used for a female actor, many women prefer to have the same title as men.

Character: This is the individual named in the story world. It is the individual that situations and events happen to or whose story is being told. The process of finding the character traits of a character for acting purposes is called characterization. **Characterisation** is the art of creating a character. Within the text, characters may be presented by means of description within stage directions or character descriptions which the actor must try to convey or through their actions, speech, or spoken thoughts within the text. Character should not be confused with the narrator. Narrator is the one who tells the story in the fictional world. Sometimes a narrator can also be a character. For example the narrator in Efua Sutherlands Play the Marriage of Anansewa is also a character.

Playwright: The author of a play. Also known as a dramatist and this is normally used to refer to authors of stage plays. A screenwriter is the author of a screen play while a writer is a general term used to refer to all those who author fictional stories in whatever form.

A script is the text of a play, containing the words spoken by the actors. Also contains stage directions and other notes. On the other hand, story is the fictional account of characters' interactions

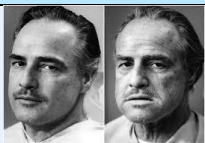
A text is the content of the story of a play. It is the explicit meaning in a play. Subtext or undertone is content of a book, play, musical work, film, video game, or television series which

is not announced explicitly by the characters (or author) but is implicit or becomes something understood by the observer of the work as the production unfolds.

A mime is Form of performance with no spoken words. Plot, character etc. are conveyed to the audience by movement and gesture. From the Greek *Mimos*.

Pantomime is the art of acting without words. While in miming the words may be formed on the lips of the performer, in pantomime the actions of the body and the facial expressions are the only ones used in revelation of the meaning of the story being told. It should be noted that in some books, the two words i.e. mime and pantomime are used interchangeably

E-tivity -1.2.2 .Confusing terms in acting

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	1.2.2
Title	Confusing terms in acting
Purpose	The purpose of this E-tivity is to enable you to differentiate between confusing terms in acting
Brief summary of overall task	Search for the following terms in the online theatre dictionaries; Mime, Pantomime, actor, character http://www.theatrecrafts.com/pages/home/glossary-of-technical-theatre-terms/letter/?search=P&submit3=Search
Spark	 Marlon Brando as Don Vito Coleaone in The Godfather
Individual task	- Search for the meaning of the terms from the words - Write the terms down as definitions while you note the key differences
Interaction begins	- Post two themes that are common in the relationship between psychology and Acting - Provide positive and constructive feedback on the team learners 'views and ideas. Do this on the discussion forum 1.2.2
E-moderator interventions	- Ensure that learners are focused on the contents and context of discussion. - Stimulate further learning and generation of new ideas. - Provide feedback on the learning progress. - Round-up the E-tivity
Schedule and time	This task should take two hours
Next	Relative groups of acting terms

1.2.3 Relative Groups of Acting Terms

In order to group acting terms, we use the kind of art that those terms are used. For example there are terms relative to theatre, film and television. While most terms cut across the three forms of visual arts, there are those that are specific to each of them. A term like cue cuts across the three forms yet blocking is specific to theatre. Terms relating to the stage like stage left or covering are typically theatre terms while camera oriented terms like eyeline are typically film and television.

E-tivity 1.2.3- Relative terms in acting

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	1.2.3
Title	Relative terms in acting
Purpose	The purpose of this E-tivity is to enable you to group terms in acting into their relative groups
Brief summary of overall task	Read the materials on these links https://www.stagemilk.com/actors-dictionary/
Spark	
Individual task	Group the terms in the link above as either belonging to theatre, film, television or two of them or all of them
Interaction begins	- Post your response in discussion forum 1.2.3 - Read what your colleagues have posted and provide at least two comments - Provide positive and constructive feedback. Do this on the discussion forum 1.2.3
E-moderator interventions	- Ensure that learners are focused on the contents and context of discussion. - Stimulate further learning and generation of new ideas. - Provide feedback on the learning progress. - Round-up the E-tivity
Schedule and time	This task should take two hours
Next	Drama Conventions

1.3 Assessment Questions

- is defined as the art of acting without words
 - Blocking
 - Sign language
 - Mime
 - Theatre

2. The term acting belongs to which of the following forms of art;
 - a) Film
 - b) Theatre
 - c) Television
 - d) All of the above

3. ----- is defined as the individual taking part in the story or the one who the action revolves around'
 - a) Character
 - b) actor
 - c) playwright
 - d) writer

4. Which of the following terms is not relative to theatre;
 - a) Cue
 - b) eye line
 - c) Action
 - d) Rehearsal

1.4 References

- 1 Theatrecraft (n.d). Concept and Terms in Theatre. Retrieved from <http://www.theatre crafts.com/pages/home/glossary-of-technical-theatre-terms/>
- 2 Sanskriti (2017, Sep 12). Definition of acting and various acting Theories. Retrieved from <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hsSqf2Dxmbw>
- 3 Templeton, P. (n.d.) *Glossary of Acting Terms*. Retrieved from <https://pennytempletonstudio.com/acting-resources/glossary-of-acting-terms/>
- 4 [StageMilk Team](#) (2016, May 10th). *Actors' Dictionary*. Retrieved from <https://www.stagemilk.com/actors-dictionary/>

1.5 Further Reading

Shanker, H & Ommanney. K. (1999). *The stage and the School*, 8th ed. New York: McGraw-Hill